

Gesualdo / Take 6

Evening concert plan - vocal harmony without voices

Concept

This evening presents vocal music without voices. Gesualdo's madrigals and sacred pieces were written for five or six voices. Take 6 works in a very different idiom - gospel, jazz, pop, and studio vocal virtuosity - but it also depends on several independent voices forming one harmonic body.

The concert can begin with a short four-voice piece played without naming its composer. The audience may hear Renaissance, Baroque, or sacred harmony before the reveal: it is the Beach Boys' Our Prayer. This makes the opening both playful and precise: four voices can pass directly into four strings, before the harder reductions begin.

The string quartet cannot reproduce the words, breath, or vocal blend of the originals. It can make other things clear: counterpoint, harmonic structure, register, and the movement from one sonority to another. The practical question is simple: what can be kept when five or six vocal lines have to become four string parts?

Why Reduce This Music for String Quartet

The string quartet is not just a practical four-part ensemble. It is often treated as a quintessence of Western harmonic and contrapuntal music. In a Weberian sense, it can be heard as a highly rationalized musical medium: four independent tuned instruments, written notation, controlled voice-leading, and a long history of harmonic thought.

This makes the quartet a strong test for Gesualdo and Take 6. Both repertoires were made for voices, but both depend on the relation between independent lines and harmonic result. Reducing them for quartet asks whether their essential musical events can survive in one of the most demanding instrumental formats.

The project also has a practical artistic goal: to enrich the string quartet repertoire with music that normally belongs to vocal ensembles, and to make Gesualdo's repertoire better known, more playable, and more alive for contemporary listeners.

Programme

#	Piece	Source	Time	Function
1	<i>Anonymous opening chorale</i> revealed later as The Beach Boys, Our Prayer	4 voices	1:08	Short opening question
2	Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Luci serene e chiare</i>	5 voices	2:59	Opening Gesualdo example
3	Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Dolcissima mia vita</i>	5 voices	2:15	Short lyrical madrigal
4	Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Gia piansi nel dolore</i>	5 voices	2:37	Chromatic expression of grief
5	Carlo Gesualdo, <i>S'io non miro non moro</i>	5 voices	2:00	Compact madrigal; Mantovani link
6	Take 6, <i>Come Unto Me</i>	6 vocal parts	2:13	First Take 6 comparison
7	Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Moro, lasso, al mio duolo</i>	5 voices	2:58	Central Gesualdo example
8	Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Sparge la morte</i>	5 voices	2:49	Contrasting madrigal texture
9	Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Belta, poi che t'assenti</i>	5 voices	2:11	Stravinsky connection
10	Carlo Gesualdo, <i>Tristis est anima mea</i>	6 voices	3:00	Six-voice sacred work
11	Take 6, <i>Hark! The Herald Angels Sing</i>	6 vocal parts	2:32	Bright late-program contrast
12	Take 6, <i>A Quiet Place</i>	6 vocal parts	2:46	Final calm piece

AI Argument

A central part of the project is the custom AI system developed for these reductions. The problem is not only to remove notes. The system has to choose between many competing constraints: preserving important lines, keeping characteristic dissonances and chromatic motions, respecting instrument ranges and sweet spots, avoiding unreadable notation, and producing something a quartet can actually play.

This is an unusual use of AI, but one that is worthwhile: AI as complex problem solving, involving no issues about copyright or ethics. Here the goal is to transform a given piece to make it playable by a quartet. This AI makes reduction decisions explicit, tests alternatives, detects issues, and helps balance antagonistic musical constraints.

The final scores are not automatic transcriptions, but the result of a guided process combining musical judgment, algorithms, notation cleanup, and listening.

Overall Timing

Nominal music duration: about 29:30. Realistic performed music duration: about 32-33 minutes. With transitions and short spoken islands: about 41-42 minutes. Total spoken introduction and discussion: about 18-20 minutes. Total event: about 59-62 minutes.

The evening should feel like a concert first and a conference second: short spoken islands, then music. The explanations should sharpen listening rather than interrupt it.

Musical Shape

Prologue - anonymous four-part harmony: Our Prayer, played first as a listening question before the composer is revealed.

Part I - Gesualdo madrigal language: Luci serene e chiare; Dolcissima mia vita; Già piansi nel dolore; S'io non miro non moro.

Part II - Comparison and central examples: Come Unto Me; Moro, lasso, al mio duolo; Sparge la morte; Belta, poi che t'assenti.

Part III - Six-voice and closing pieces: Tristis est anima mea; Hark! The Herald Angels Sing; A Quiet Place.

Spoken Islands

Opening, 1 minute before the first piece: ask the audience to listen without a label. Is it Renaissance, Baroque, sacred, modern? Then play the anonymous opening.

After the opening piece, 3-4 minutes: reveal the Beach Boys; introduce vocal music without voices; explain why Gesualdo and Take 6 are in the same programme and why the string quartet is a useful medium.

After piece 3 or before piece 4, 3 minutes: what a madrigal is; how words create musical decisions; why chromatic voice-leading matters more than isolated chords.

Before Come Unto Me, 3 minutes: why Take 6 belongs here; six vocal parts as a modern comparison to Gesualdo's multi-voice writing.

Before Moro, lasso, 4 minutes: the AI/reduction problem. Explain the competing constraints: keep essential musical events, fit four instruments, preserve readable notation, and avoid losing the character of the original.

Before Tristis or Hark, 4 minutes: place the last group clearly: one six-voice Gesualdo work, then two Take 6 pieces to close the evening in a different harmonic world.

Closing Formulation

The concert does not try to make Gesualdo and Take 6 the same. It uses the quartet to compare two kinds of complex vocal harmony. Gesualdo shows how chromatic voice-leading can create extraordinary tension. Take 6 shows another use of dense harmony: clarity, blend, and consolation. The AI system is the tool that makes this comparison playable and inspectable.